Release Readiness & Strategy

Plan how a change reaches users, check it's ready, know how to undo it, and tell the people who need to know.

Engineering Practices · Separate Deploy from Release · Go / No-Go

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

RELEASE: Substitutes 1.0

TARGET DATE: 2 June

1 What's Releasing

Release / version: Substitutes 1.0

Outcome for users: no gaps when items are out

Main changes: swap screen; customer approval

Who's affected: pilot-store customers, pickers

Deploy date: 28 May (switched off)

Switch-on date: 2 June, one store

2 Release Approach

TICK ONE OR COMBINE · DEPLOYING ISN'T THE SAME AS RreleasING

- [ ] **Big bang** — Everyone gets it at once. Simple, but the riskiest.
- [x] **Feature flag** — Deploy switched off, then turn it on when ready, for some or all. ← switch on per store
- [ ] **Canary** — A small share of users first, then more if all is well.
- [ ] **Blue-green** — Switch traffic to a new copy; switch back if it goes wrong.
- [x] **Phased rollout** — By region, customer group or channel, one at a time. ← one store, then all 12 in July
- [ ] **Beta / early access** — Volunteers try it first and give feedback.

3 Go / No-Go Checklist

AGREE THE LIST BEFORE THE DAY

- [x] Definition of Done met for every item
- [x] Pipeline green, no open critical defects
- [x] Performance and security checks done
- [x] Rollback tested, not just written down
- [x] Monitoring and alerts ready
- [x] Support and operations briefed
- [x] Release notes and messages ready
- [ ] Data migration rehearsed (if any) n/a
- [x] Change approval recorded (if needed)
- [x] Someone on hand after release

Decision: [x] Go [ ] No-go Decided by: Priya, Store Ops lead When: 30 May

4 Rollback & Recovery

PLAN TO UNDO IT BEFORE YOU DO IT

If it goes wrong, we'll see: swap complaints, picking time up, error alerts

We'll undo it by: turning the flag off for the store

Time to undo: under 5 minutes

Who decides to roll back: on-call developer, or the store manager

What we can't undo (data, messages): swap emails already sent

Rollback last tested on: 27 May, on staging

5 Who Needs to Know

USERS, SUPPORT, SALES, OTHER TEAMS

AUDIENCE	WHAT THEY NEED TO KNOW	WHEN	HOW	OWNER
Pilot-store customers	swaps are coming; how to approve them	31 May	email + app	Mei
Pickers, pilot store	the new swap screen	29 May	huddle + practice	Store Ops
Customer service	what customers will see, FAQs	30 May	briefing	Priya
Other product teams	it's live in one store	2 June	#releases	Tom

6 After Release

Check the outcome on: 16 June (two weeks in)

Remove the feature flag by: end of July, after all stores

What we learned:

"If this goes wrong at the worst moment, what's our plan?"

"Could we release this a little at a time?"

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